

systematically doubt everything, and thus attain a level of serenity. But while conservative in their habits, they were rabid in their fight against dogma.

Among the surviving works of Sextus's is a diatribe with the beautiful title *Adversos Mathematicos*, sometimes translated as *Against the Professors*. Much of it could have been written last Wednesday night!

Where Sextus is mostly interesting for my ideas is in his rare mixing of philosophy and decision making in his practice. He was a doer, hence classical scholars don't say nice things about him. The methods of empirical medicine, relying on seemingly purposeless trial and error, will be central to my ideas on planning and prediction, on how to benefit from the Black Swan.

In 1998, when I went out on my own, I called my research laboratory and trading firm Empirica, not for the same antidogmatist reasons, but on account of the far more depressing reminder that it took at least another fourteen centuries after the works of the school of empirical medicine before medicine changed and finally became adogmatic, suspicious of theorizing, profoundly skeptical, and evidence-based! Lesson? That awareness of a problem does not mean much—particularly when you have special interests and self-serving institutions in play.

Algazel

The third major thinker who dealt with the problem was the eleventh-century Arabic-language skeptic Al-Ghazali, known in Latin as Algazel. His name for a class of dogmatic scholars was *ghabi*, literally “the imbeciles,” an Arabic form that is funnier than “moron” and more expressive than “obscurantist.” Algazel wrote his own *Against the Professors*, a diatribe called *Tahafut al falasifah*, which I translate as “The Incompetence of Philosophers.” It was directed at members of the school called *falasifah*—the Arabic intellectual establishment was the direct heir of the classical philosophy of the academy, and they managed to reconcile it with Islam through rational argument.

Algazel's attack on “scientific” knowledge started a debate with Averroës, the medieval philosopher who ended up having the most profound influence of any medieval thinker (on Jews and Christians, though not on Moslems). The debate between Algazel and Averroës was finally, but sadly, won by both. In its aftermath, many Arab religious thinkers integrated and exaggerated Algazel's skepticism of the scientific method, preferring to leave causal considerations to God (in fact it was a stretch of his idea). The West embraced Averroës's rationalism, built upon Aristotle's, which survived through Aquinas and the Jewish philosophers who called themselves Averroan for a long time. Many thinkers blame the Arabs' later abandonment of scientific